moral character. And the personal realm is not part of the problem — as is suggested by the *liberal* narrative — but rather the primary realm where change needs to take place.

Many of the country's current problems are seen to stem from a long-standing *ar nar shin* or dictatorial style of leadership (Interview 1, 2013 Burmese). A true-hearted leader (*tage seit shi de lu*) can provide a means to overcome the everyday conflicts that emerge from the political realm. Supporting this leadership requires a commitment among citizens to unity. For proponents of this narrative, Burma was born into instability and unification of the country under a benevolent leader has been the unrealized goal since the country's independence. Ethnic and ideological division soured the early years of civilian government. And while the decades of military leadership may have enforced a degree of national unity, it came via the *ar nar shin* style of leadership by a self-interested few.

Thus, the unification of the country is seen to require an emphasis on the obligations (as opposed to the rights) of individuals. A member of the National League for Democracy (NLD) (Interview 8, 2013 Burmese) explained that in a democratic country, rights need to be "balanced with obligations". If democracy is about rights alone, it will lead to instability in society, as everyone will be guided by self-interest (Interview 8, 2013 Burmese). Rather, as Aung San Suu Kyi suggests in *Freedom from Fear*, "free men" are the ones who "make themselves fit to bear the responsibilities and to uphold the disciplines which will maintain a free society" (1991, p. 183).

This focus on unity also leads to an emphasis on protection of the country's Buddhist majority from sectarian, minority interests — especially those of Muslims. As one local NGO leader described:

> Buddhism is not confrontational. … But Muslims in Myanmar are systematically threatening the country, infiltrating into the country. If we keep the status quo they will grab the whole society — which is what happened in Indonesia and Malaysia which were originally Buddhist countries. Muslims are very aggressive. … Buddhism needs a defence system, otherwise we will have to be backed into the ocean. We do not want to attack, but just defend (Interview 46, 2014 Burmese).

The facts articulated in this quote may be disputed, yet what is important is the underlying logic of majority protection, rooted in a commitment to the ideal of unity. While in the *liberal* narrative, human rights is the inviolable framework through which to consider the issue of communal violence, for some in the democracy movement, the inviolable dimension is unity.